

VESUVIO: Blood of Naples — Story Bible

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VESUVIO: Blood of Naples

Official Story Bible

An original series created by Ciprian Stefan Plesca

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1. Logline & Premise

For ten years, an uneasy peace has held the criminal underworld of Naples together. When a single act of betrayal breaks that peace, three generations of one family — bound by blood, honor, and the mountain that watches over them — are forced to choose between loyalty to the past and survival in the present.

VESUVIO: Blood of Naples is a modern mafia drama set in contemporary Naples, Italy. It is not a nostalgia piece about “the old ways” — it is a story about what happens when the old codes collide with a modern world that no longer respects them: surveillance, global finance, fractured alliances, and a new generation unwilling to inherit their parents’ rules without question.

The city itself is a character. Mount Vesuvius, dormant but never silent, looms over every frame — a constant reminder that peace here is always temporary.

2. The World of Naples

Naples is presented not as postcard Italy, but as a living, breathing, contradictory city: sun-bleached palazzos beside crumbling social housing; Baroque churches beside abandoned factories; tourists on the Lungomare unaware of the war being fought three streets inland.

The show draws a hard line between two Naples:

- **La Napoli di sopra** (“Upper Naples”) — the historic center, the tourist economy, the political and legal establishment, the world that pretends the Camorra does not exist.
- **La Napoli di sotto** (“Lower Naples”) — the *rioni* (housing-block neighborhoods), the ports, the outer *quartieri* — where the Camorra is not a rumor but a government.

The series lives almost entirely in the second Naples, occasionally crossing into the first to show how thin the line between them really is.

3. Timeline & History

- **1980s-90s:** The founding generation consolidates territory in the chaos following Naples’ historical clan wars. The family at the center of the show is established during this period.
 - **10 years before the pilot:** A fragile truce (“*a Pace*” — “the Peace”) is struck between the major clans after a war that nearly destroyed all of them. This truce is the bedrock the entire present-day story stands on.
 - **Present day (Season 1):** The Peace begins to crack. An act of betrayal — deliberately left ambiguous in early episodes — triggers the central conflict of the series.
 - **Series-long arc:** Multi-season structure tracking the slow collapse and violent reformation of power in Naples, mirrored against Vesuvius itself — dormant, then erupting.
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4. Politics & Power Structure

Power in the world of VESUVIO operates on three interlocking levels:

1. **The Street** — territorial control of neighborhoods, extortion (*'o pizzo*), drug distribution, and local enforcement.
2. **The Business** — legitimate-front companies (construction, waste management, import/export, real estate) used to launder and expand influence into the legal economy.
3. **The Institutions** — a shifting, deniable network of relationships with police, local politicians, and the judiciary. Corruption here is never absolute; it is negotiated, situational, and always at risk of exposure — a core source of dramatic tension.

The series is explicit that the Camorra is not a single hierarchical “mafia” like fictional depictions of Cosa Nostra — it is a decentralized network of semi-independent *clans*, each with its own boss, territory, and rules, sometimes allied, sometimes at war, held together only by temporary agreements like “the Peace.”

5. Camorra Structure

A simplified in-world hierarchy used consistently across the series:

- **Il Capo (The Boss)** — head of a clan; final authority on territory, war, and peace.
 - **Il Sottocapo (The Underboss)** — second-in-command; often the boss’s most trusted enforcer or a designated successor.
 - **I Capizona (Zone Captains)** — control individual neighborhoods or business sectors on the boss’s behalf.
 - **Gli Affiliati (Affiliates / Soldiers)** — street-level enforcers, runners, and lookouts; the entry point into the organization.
 - **I Prestanome (“Name-lenders”)** — legitimate businesspeople who front companies for the clan, often unwillingly.
 - **Gli Amici degli Amici (“Friends of Friends”)** — the deniable outer ring: officials, lawyers, and intermediaries who benefit from the clan without formally belonging to it.
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6. The Families

(Full biographical detail for individual characters lives in [/characters/](#). This section covers the family/clan units.)

- **Famiglia Ranieri** — the show’s central family; controllers of the docks and construction trade; architects and guardians of “the Peace.”
 - **Clan Esposito** — a rising, younger, more volatile faction impatient with the old rules; the primary antagonistic force in Season 1.
 - **The Institutional Fringe** — a recurring set of police, legal, and political figures who orbit both families without full allegiance to either.
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7. Key Locations

Location	Narrative Function
The Rione	Home turf of the Ranieri family; the emotional center of the show
The Port of Naples	Economic engine of the family's power; site of major set-pieces
Mount Vesuvius (exteriors)	Visual motif; recurring establishing shots signaling tonal shifts
The Family Villa	Private, "sacred" space where the family's rules are absolute
The Historic Center	Where the family interacts with police, politicians, and "legitimate" Naples
The Church	Site of ritual, confession, funerals, and uneasy morality

8. Rules & Codes of Conduct

The world of VESUVIO operates on an unwritten but rigidly enforced code, echoed directly in the show's theme song:

- **Silence ('o silenzio)** — nothing is said that doesn't need to be said; information is currency, and leaking it is a capital offense.
- **Respect ('o rispetto)** — earned, never given; publicly enforced, privately negotiated.
- **No mistakes, no tears (nu sgarro, nu chianto)** — emotional display, especially in front of rivals, is treated as weakness.
- **Debts are always paid ('a morte se sconta)** — literally and figuratively; the show treats debt (financial, moral, blood) as its central engine of plot.
- **Family before law** — but never stated as ideology; shown, episode after episode, as the operating assumption of every character.

9. Religion & Ritual

Catholic ritual is woven through the show not as decoration but as a genuine, contradictory moral framework the characters live inside: baptisms, funerals, and confession scenes double as plot delivery mechanisms and character studies. The **priest** (see </characters/>) is a recurring figure who represents the story's central moral question: can the code and the confessional coexist?

10. Money & Economy

The economic backbone of the family's power runs through:

- Port logistics and shipping contracts (legitimate front)
- Construction and public-works contracts (legitimate front)
- Territorial extortion, 'o pizzo (illegitimate)

- Narcotics distribution (illegitimate)
- Real estate laundering (grey zone)

The show is careful to depict money as a *structural* force rather than a prop — every major plot turn in Season 1 can be traced back to a specific financial pressure point.

11. Weapons & Violence

Violence in VESUVIO is treated as consequence, not spectacle. Guidelines for the writers' room and director:

- Violence is sudden, brief, and costly — never choreographed for entertainment.
- The show avoids fetishizing weaponry; guns and blades are shown as tools of last resort, not identity markers.
- Aftermath (grief, cover-up, institutional consequence) is given equal or greater screen time than the act itself.

12. Vocabulary & Dialect Guide

A living glossary of Neapolitan terms used consistently across scripts — see also the theme song lyrics in [/docs/LYRICS_BILINGUAL.md](#).

Neapolitan	English	Usage
'o rione	the neighborhood	Home turf, identity
'o pizzo	protection money	Extortion payment
'o silenzio	the silence	Code of secrecy
'o rispetto	respect	Earned social currency
'o putere	power	Central thematic word
sanghe	blood	Family, violence, kinship
'a Pace	the Peace	The truce the season threatens to break
guaglió	young man / kid	Informal address
'a legge	the law	Institutional authority, often ironic

13. Themes & Tone

- **Loyalty vs. survival** — what happens when doing right by the family means doing wrong by yourself.
- **Tradition vs. modernity** — a younger generation inheriting a code built for a world that no longer exists.
- **The city as inheritance** — Naples itself as something fought over, loved, and feared in equal measure.

Tonally, the reference point is prestige crime drama — grounded, character-first, morally complex — rather than genre pastiche.

14. Series Arc

Season 1 establishes the Peace, the families, and the betrayal that breaks it — ending on a point of no return. **Season 2** tracks open conflict between the families as institutional pressure closes in. **Season 3** resolves the founding generation’s story and hands the world to its successors, closing the thematic loop the theme song opens: “*Ccà cumandammo nuje*” — “We command here.”

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